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Everyday Holiness

Week 3 · The Stress Response

Last week you learned the model. This week you learn what happens when you are too overwhelmed to use it. Because there are moments when the thinking part of you goes offline and your body takes the wheel -- and no amount of good theology reaches you in that moment. This week is about those moments. What your body is doing, why it is not sin, and the protocol to use when you cannot manage anything else.

YOUR BODY IS NOT BETRAYING YOU

The Catechism says something most of us were never taught: "In themselves passions are neither good nor evil" (CCC 1767). The surge you feel when your child screams, the flood of dread when the bill arrives, the shutdown when it is all too much -- that is not a moral failure. That is a body doing exactly what God designed it to do to protect you. It only becomes something to confess when reason and will step in and choose wrongly. Which means: the feeling is not the sin. What you do next is where you live free or not free. And Jesus Himself sweat blood in a garden. He knows this from the inside.

+ *"The Lord is near to the brokenhearted, and saves the crushed in spirit." -- Psalm 34:18*

THE FOUR RESPONSES

RESPONSE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	MOST PRONE
FIGHT	Control, criticize, argue, tighten the grip. Anger arrives first because it feels stronger than fear.	*Choleric*
FLIGHT	Busy, scroll, clean, escape, overschedule. Anything but sit in it.	*Sanguine*
FREEZE	Shut down, go numb, stare at the wall. Calm on the outside, drowning underneath.	*Melancholic*
FAWN	Manage everyone's feelings, apologize first, keep the peace at your own cost.	*Phlegmatic*

Your temperament makes one of these your default. It is not your only one -- and it is not your character.

WEEK 3 *O -- Overflow*

> *"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness." -- 2 Corinthians 12:9*

Overflow asks what is actually moving through you. In a stress response, the honest answer is almost never the first thing you would say. It is not really anger -- anger is the bodyguard. Underneath is usually fear, or grief, or exhaustion you have been ignoring for days. Naming the real one is not indulgent. It is the thing that takes its hands off the wheel.

MORNING REFLECTION · WEEK 3

Which of the four is your default -- Fight, Flight, Freeze, or Fawn? Where did you see it this week specifically?

Think of your most recent stress moment. What did you say it was about? Now: what was it actually about?

Name the emotion underneath the reaction as precisely as you can. Not 'upset' -- the real word.

What has your body been trying to tell you that you have been too busy to hear?

THE HARD-MOMENT PROTOCOL

For the moments when the full model is too much. Five steps. Two minutes. Sometimes thirty seconds.

1

PAUSE AND NAME IT
Out loud if you can: "I am having a stress response." That sentence alone pulls you from inside the wave to standing beside it.

2

REALITY
One sentence of fact. What is actually happening -- not what it means, not the worst case. Just what a camera would record.

3

THE ABANDONMENT PRAYER
"Father, I abandon myself into Your hands. Do with me what You will." You do not have to mean it fully. Say it anyway.

4

ONE SMALL STEP
Not the whole solution. The next faithful inch. Drink water. Step outside. Apologize. Sit down on the floor.

5

RECEIVE
Do not perform your way out of this. Let God look at you in it. You are not required to be fixed before you are loved.

WRITE YOUR OWN PROTOCOL

Where will you most likely need this protocol this week? Name the actual room, hour, and people.

What is your one small step -- decided now, in the calm, so you do not have to decide in the storm?

Who can you tell about this? Fawn and Freeze both isolate. Name one person.

NEW THIS WEEK · THE BRIDGE THOUGHT

There is a gap between what is true and what you can believe today. When you are in a stress response, "I am a beloved daughter of God" can feel so far away it is almost insulting. So you reach for it, fail, and conclude your faith is weak. It is not. You were just trying to leap a canyon. A Bridge Thought is the plank across. It is one sentence that holds your struggle and God's mercy in the same breath -- true enough to be honest, near enough to be believed tonight. It does not skip the hard part. It just refuses to end there.

INSTEAD OF THE LEAP	TRY THE BRIDGE
"I am completely at peace about this."	*"I am not at peace yet -- and God is not asking me to fake it."*
"I am a patient mother."	*"I lost my temper, and mercy is still available to me at 5pm."*
"My body never betrays me."	*"My body did what it learned to do to protect me. It is not sin. And I do not have to stay here."*

WRITE YOUR BRIDGE THOUGHT

Name the struggle honestly in the first half. Let mercy have the second half. Test it: can you say it tonight and not flinch?

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

Use the protocol at least once when you actually need it. Say your Bridge Thought every night before bed, whether the day was hard or easy -- especially when it was easy. You are wearing the path in now, so it exists when you need it.

BRIDGE THOUGHT SPOKEN · PROTOCOL USED	S	M	T	W	T	F	S

+ *"He touched him and said, Arise and eat, for the journey is too great for you." -- 1 Kings 19:7*